Document 1: Tent Guide

Harbour & Pine Outdoor Co. Tent Buying and Setup Guide

This guide explains how to choose the right Harbour & Pine tent and how to pitch it properly. A tent that suits your trip and is pitched well will keep you dry and comfortable for many seasons.

Our tent range

We make three tents. The Gull is our lightweight tent for one or two people. It weighs 1.9 kg and costs $249. The Heron sleeps three or four people, weighs 3.4 kg and costs $389. The Osprey is our family tent. It sleeps four to six people, weighs 5.8 kg and costs $549.

Every tent has a flysheet, an inner tent and a sewn-in groundsheet. The flysheet is the waterproof outer layer. The inner tent is the breathable layer you sleep in. Each tent comes with pegs, guy lines and a small repair kit.

Choosing the right size

The stated capacity of a tent assumes people lying side by side with no space for bags. If you want room for backpacks, or if you are tall, choose a tent rated for one more person than you need. For example, two adults who want space for their packs should choose the Heron rather than the Gull.

Weight matters if you are carrying the tent. For a two-day hike, most walkers choose the Gull and split the load, with one person carrying the inner tent and poles and the other carrying the flysheet and pegs. For car camping, where weight does not matter, the Osprey gives the most living space. It has a standing height of 190 cm at the centre, so most adults can stand up inside.

Seasons and waterproofing

All Harbour & Pine tents are three-season tents, which means they are designed for spring, summer and autumn. They are not designed for heavy snow or winter camping, and we do not sell a four-season tent.

Waterproofing is measured in millimetres of hydrostatic head. This number shows how much water pressure the fabric can take before water starts to come through, so a higher number means more waterproof. Every flysheet is rated at 3,000 mm. Every groundsheet is rated at 5,000 mm. The groundsheet has a higher rating because your weight pushes water up from the ground.

Choosing a pitch

Spend a few minutes choosing your spot. Look for flat ground that is free of sharp stones and sticks. Avoid dips and the bottom of slopes, because rain collects there. If the ground slopes slightly, sleep with your head at the higher end. Do not pitch under dead branches, which can fall in wind. Camp at least 30 metres away from rivers and lakes.

A footprint is a thin sheet that goes under the tent to protect the groundsheet from stones and wear. We sell footprints for $39 for the Gull, $49 for the Heron and $59 for the Osprey. A footprint is optional. Make sure it is slightly smaller than the tent floor, so rain cannot run down the edges and collect underneath.

Pitching step by step

Once you have done it a couple of times, pitching takes about 5 minutes for the Gull, 10 minutes for the Heron and 15 to 20 minutes for the Osprey. Practise once at home before your first trip.

First, lay out the footprint if you are using one, then spread the inner tent on top and peg down the corners. Second, join the pole sections. The poles are shock-corded, which means a stretchy cord runs through them. Join the sections gently and do not let them snap together. Third, thread the poles through the sleeves or attach the clips, and raise the tent. Fourth, peg out the corners tightly. Fifth, drape the flysheet over the tent, clip it down and tension it. The flysheet must not touch the inner tent, because water can seep through wherever the two touch.

Pegs and guy lines

Each tent comes with enough pegs for the corners and for the guy lines. Push pegs into the ground at a 45 degree angle, leaning away from the tent. Always use every guy line in windy weather. Guy lines spread the load, and a tent with all its guy lines in use is much more stable than one with only the corners pegged.

If the ground is too hard or too sandy for the pegs to hold, tie a guy line to a heavy rock, or bury a peg flat in the ground and cover it with stones.

Wind and heavy rain

Pitch with the narrow end of the tent facing into the wind and the door facing away from it. We do not recommend using any of our tents in sustained winds above 40 mph. If a storm arrives, check all the pegs and guy lines and move your gear away from the walls of the tent.

In heavy rain, keep wet boots and jackets in the porch, not in the sleeping area. Open the porch only when you need to, so rain does not blow inside.

Condensation

Condensation is water that forms on the inside of the tent because your breath and body heat make the air damp. It is normal and is not a leak. To reduce it, open the vents at the top of the flysheet, leave the porch door partly open when the weather allows, and avoid cooking inside the tent. Wipe the inside of the tent with a dry cloth in the morning.

Taking down and packing

Shake off loose dirt and water before you pack the tent. Make sure the tent is completely dry before you pack it away for storage, because a damp tent will grow mould. If you have to pack up in the rain, put the tent up again at home within 24 hours and let it dry fully indoors or in the shade.

Fold the tent loosely, in a different pattern each time so the fabric does not crease along the same lines. Store it in a cool, dry place, away from direct sunlight, which weakens the fabric over time.